

On the wings of dragons



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Many of us scoff at the fact that India's space program isn't something to boast about. To give you a cricket analogy, if NASA and the ESA are two star batsmen at the crease, throwing the stadium's crowd and television audiences all over in raptures, then India's equivalent space program is like the 12th man running towards the two players with refreshments. We're good, but not great. That we're still busy engaged in a commercial satellite launch race whereas NASA, Russia, ESA and other elite space agencies of the world are capable of greater feats and embarking upon full-scale solar space exploration, is worth a thought.

One reason for this dichotomy is ISRO's focus, not counting the fact that we entered the space race much later than other more established players. India's space program has traditionally focused on technological, scientific and social development issues through enhancing space capabilities. For e.g., we have one of the largest satellite communication networks in the world; we largely use satellites for applications such as national resource management, weather forecasting, communications and defense. Only recently have we shown any foresight in launching space exploration missions, like Mangalyaan, which isn't the same as NASA's Curiosity, and still en route to Mars. Chandrayaan-1 is a good example of Indian space innovation, but even this giant leap in space is only meant for better understanding the origin of our planet's moon, not to search for extraterrestrial life.

Not to say that better understanding the moon is of any less importance. It's a logical first step towards soft-landing unmanned rovers in the near future, and using the moon as a launchpad for deeper space exploration. It's just that the rhetoric around exploring the moon isn't new and definitely not at the same level as the much more thought-provoking and inspiring quest towards the search of extraterrestrial life. Ask yourself what sounds more exciting: Exploring the moon or searching for life beyond our planet? If the same question was asked in a classroom full of school students, which answer has the greater capacity to excite? The search for ET may be a fool's hope

in the vast emptiness of interstellar space, but that's far from the point. It's about asking the right questions to unlock the imagination of a generation that ultimately matters. And with the help of technology, not only asking exciting questions but also achieving the extraordinary is within the realms of possibility.

I'm only taking the case of ISRO because it recently launched five foreign satellites from Sriharikota via PSLV-C23 rocket. If ISRO shows the appetite, it too can play a role similar to that of NASA in ushering a technological age in the US after WWII. It's all about asking tough questions, unlocking imagination by giving flight to dreams like we've never experienced here in India. It's not about treating waste water as it enters the sea but about building floating or submerged cities (Rapture from Bioshock, anyone?). We can build a humanoid robot but can it truly be sentient? When can we truly become immortal? (www.2045.com)

Can we turn our backs on some of our country's pressing problems like poverty, social inequality, unemployment, etc? Of course not. But I also think that somehow radical innovations in technology (spurred on by breakthrough feats) is connected to alleviating some of these problems faster and better. After all what is technology if not a means to an end? That is ultimately what lights the blue touch paper, in a matter of saying.

A wiser man once said to me that "Wings can't save you from your plight; it is conviction that gives you flight!" Technology is disrupting almost every aspect of our life – shopping, entertainment, communication, etc. If that disruptive force of technology can't be channeled for the greater good through our educational system and centers of cutting edge research, to inspire people by undertaking challenging feats, and ask truly thought-provoking questions with long-term ramifications, it will all be a big shame. 